

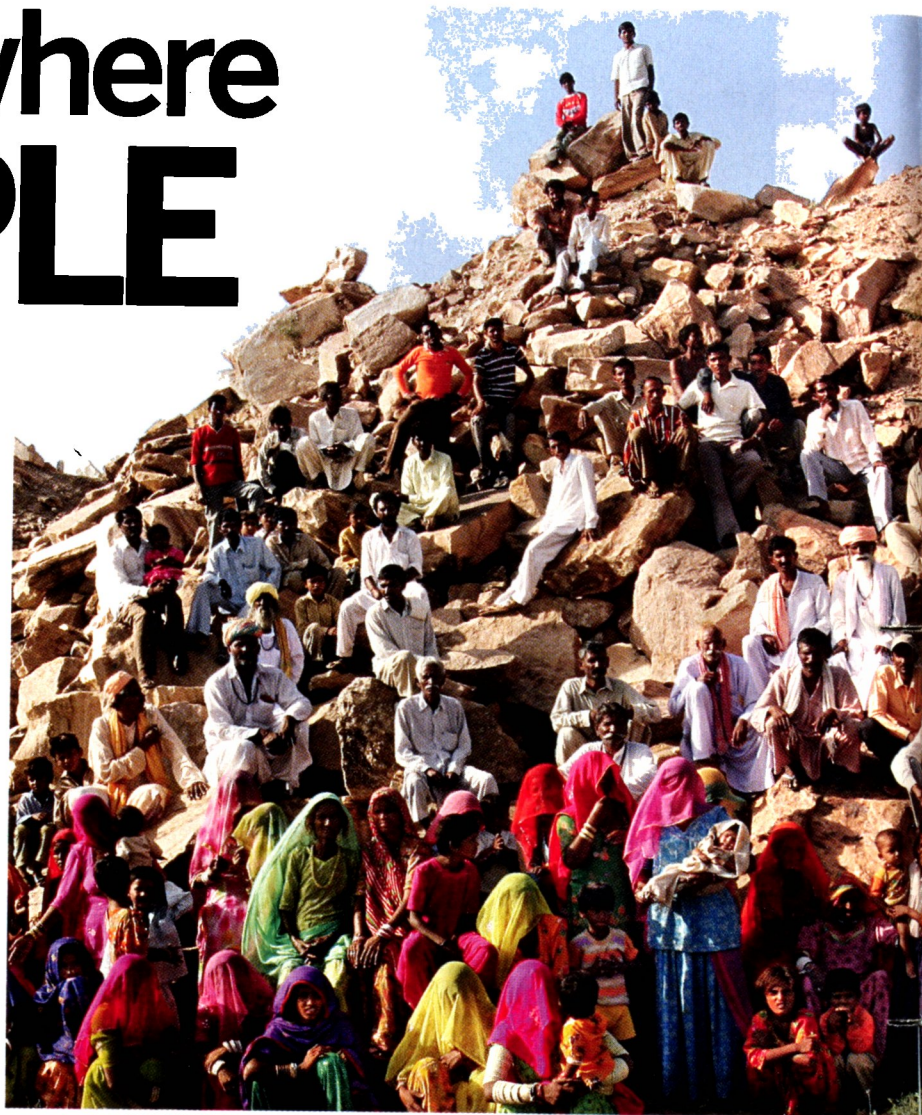
The Nowhere PEOPLE

Hindus in the border districts of Pakistan are trapped between militant Wahhabism and suspicious Indian security officials

| By Uday Mahurkar |

Along the Rajasthan border districts of Jaisalmer, Bikaner and Barmer, a replay of the tragedy that visited the subcontinent over 60 years ago is in progress as migrants from Pakistan escape persecution. This time, the Partition-type exodus has a different history. These districts saw reverse migration as poor low caste Hindus moved to Pakistan after Partition because of better employment opportunities on the other side where the desert was literally greener due to a river network. Today, these same migrants have become refugees, fleeing intimidation to change their religion, to a country which views them with hostility and suspicion.

The irony is not lost on Ranaram Bhil, 28, who fled from his village on the Punjab-Sindh border with his two children to escape the threat facing the Hindus there: convert to Islam or suffer the consequences. It's a Taliban-like decree issued by the extremist Wahhabi clergy. It took him a year to get a visa to cross to India but without his wife Samda who was abducted by a group associated with the Jamaat-e-Ulema-e-Islam (JUI) and forced to convert to Islam. All



KARIM BHIL, 24

The only graduate in the Kaliberi locality of Hindu migrants, Karim too was a victim of prejudice. One of his college teachers wanted to congratulate him on having done well in his studies. When the teacher came to know that he was a Hindu sporting a Muslim name, he refused to shake hands and made Karim sit in the last row of the class.

